

Patient Information — Stimulant Treatment for ADHD

Medication Classes

Two main classes of stimulant medications are used as first-line treatment for ADHD:

- Methylphenidate derivatives (ex: Concerta, Biphentin)
- Amphetamine derivatives (ex: Vyvanse, Adderall)

Both classes are safe and effective, but the response is individualized. Approximately one-third of patients respond better to methylphenidate-based medications, one-third respond better to amphetamine-based medications, and one-third respond well to both. A trial-and-error approach is therefore necessary to determine the best medication for each individual.

Genetic tests available for this purpose are not always associated with clinically meaningful results and do not reliably predict individual treatment response.

Taking the Medication

Stimulants are generally taken once daily in the morning. Their average duration of action is approximately 12 hours, so it is recommended to take the medication upon waking to avoid interfering with sleep.

If you forget a dose and it is already late in the day, it is often preferable not to take it in order to avoid insomnia.

Titration Process

Some patients only require very small doses, while others require moderate to higher doses. For this reason, treatment is generally started at a low dose and increased gradually.

Treatment is usually initiated at a very low dose with weekly dose increases. The goal is to find the minimum effective dose that optimizes attention and functioning while minimizing side effects.

During the first month, the prescription may be sent to the pharmacy as a progressive titration schedule and may be dispensed weekly by the pharmacist.

A follow-up appointment is usually scheduled approximately one month later to evaluate effectiveness at a moderate dose. This allows assessment of whether a dose increase or a change in medication class is needed.

It is possible that at the first few doses you may not notice any effect. This does not mean the medication is not appropriate for you, but rather that the dose may still be too low. It is important to remain patient and wait until a moderate dose has been reached before drawing conclusions.

Dose titration should continue as long as the medication is well tolerated. If an initial dose already feels very effective, it is also appropriate to notify the pharmacist in order to maintain that dose until medical follow-up.

Expected Benefits

Expected benefits include improved concentration, better ability to start and complete tasks, fewer forgetfulness issues, improved time management, reduced impulsivity, and reduced distractibility.

Some patients also report improved emotional stability, less mental chaos, and improved efficiency at work or school.

Benefits should be noticeable in everyday life: fewer mistakes, improved productivity, better organization, and improved control over impulsive behaviors.

Coffee/Tea/Energy Drinks and Other Substances

It is recommended to limit coffee intake (for example: 2 small coffees or tea per day, but not both) and to completely avoid energy drinks and other stimulants (pre-workout supplements, etc.) while taking the medication.

These products, when combined with stimulant medication, may increase side effects such as palpitations, anxiety, tremors, insomnia, or increased blood pressure. Rarely, excessive caffeine or stimulant intake may trigger more serious arrhythmias requiring emergency evaluation.

It is also recommended to avoid recreational drugs (including cannabis) during treatment.

Alcohol consumption should also be limited during treatment.

Blood Pressure Monitoring

Stimulants may slightly increase blood pressure and resting heart rate in some patients.

A mild increase in resting heart rate may occur and is usually not noticeable or dangerous.

Palpitations are less common but possible. If they become uncomfortable (heart beating quickly but regularly) or appear irregular/disorganized (rarer), a fast medical assessment is recommended.

Blood pressure monitoring is recommended during treatment, especially at the beginning and during dose increases.

Once the dose is stable, blood pressure should ideally be checked approximately once per month at the pharmacy. Seek medical attention if a lot of values are repeatedly elevated above 135/85 mm Hg

Common Side Effects

NB: The medication monograph contains the complete list of potential side effects. The effects listed below are the most common or clinically relevant. This document does not replace the official monograph, which may be consulted for additional information.

The most common side effects include:

- Decreased appetite (most common)
- Dry mouth
- Mild/transient headaches (usually mild and temporary. Tylenol may be used if necessary.)
- Increased anxiety in some patients

Tips for Appetite Suppression

- Eat a larger breakfast and supper
- Eat frequent snacks
- Consider nutritional supplements if needed (ex: Boost)

Most side effects are more noticeable at the beginning of treatment or after dose increases, then improve over time.

You should notify your physician if side effects become severe, persistent, or interfere with daily functioning.

Rare but Important Side Effects

Seek prompt medical attention if you experience:

- Chest pain
- Sustained or irregular palpitations
- Unusual shortness of breath
- Fainting
- Significant mood changes

Contraindications / Important Medical History to Mention

The following conditions represent contraindications to stimulant medications:

- Known structural heart disease
- History of cardiac arrhythmia
- Unexplained fainting
- Chest pain or exertional symptoms
- Poorly controlled high blood pressure
- Glaucoma
- Hyperthyroidism

You should also notify your physician about any family history of sudden cardiac death or arrhythmias.

It is also important to mention any personal history of:

- Psychosis
- Bipolar disorder
- Substance use disorder
- Seizures
- Eating disorders
- Anxiety or depression

Other medications and natural health products should also be disclosed.

Do not take nasal decongestants containing pseudoephedrine while taking stimulant medication.

If you are unsure whether another product interacts with your medication, your pharmacist is an appropriate resource.

How Do You Know If the Dose Is Correct?

A good dose should provide a clear improvement in symptoms without making you feel “overstimulated.”

You should feel more functional, organized, and focused, but not euphoric, nervous, or agitated.

This will be reassessed during medical follow-up.